

Materia Medica III – Yin-Tonifying Herbs

Overview

Yin-tonifying herbs nourish yin, generate fluids, clear deficiency heat, and anchor yang. They are most commonly used for **chronic deficiency patterns**, post-febrile damage, dryness, and wasting disorders. Primary organs affected include the **Lung, Stomach, Kidney, and Liver**.

Core Patterns

- **Yin deficiency:** dry mouth/throat, night sweats, red tongue (little coat)
- **Deficiency heat:** afternoon fever, irritability
- **Post-febrile injury:** thirst, dry cough

General Characteristics

Attribute	Description
Taste	Sweet (sometimes bitter)
Temperature	Neutral to cool (some cold)
Channels	Lung, Stomach, Kidney, Liver
Core Actions	Nourish yin; generate fluids; clear deficiency heat

Global Cautions

- Yin tonics may be **cloying** → caution with Spleen deficiency, dampness, or loose stools.
 - Cold yin tonics may aggravate **cold or deficiency-cold** patterns.
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Yin-Tonifying Herbs – Quick Reference Table

Herb	Nature	Channels	Core Exam Keywords
Bei Sha Shen	Cool	LU, ST	Nourishes Lung & Stomach yin; post-febrile dryness
Nan Sha Shen	Cool	LU, ST	Nourishes yin; clears phlegm

Herb	Nature	Channels	Core Exam Keywords
Mai Men Dong	Slightly cold	HT, LU, ST	Nourishes Lung & ST yin; clears Heart irritability
Tian Men Dong	Very cold	LU, KD	Clears Lung heat; nourishes KD yin
Shi Hu	Slightly cold	ST, KD	Nourishes ST yin; clears deficiency heat
Yu Zhu	Neutral	LU, ST	Nourishes yin; moistens dryness
Huang Jing	Neutral	LU, SP, KD	Tonifies qi & yin; nourishes essence
Bai He	Slightly cold	LU, HT	Moistens Lung; calms Shen
Gou Qi Zi	Neutral	LV, KD, LU	Tonifies LV/KD yin; brightens eyes

Běi Shā Shēn 北沙参

Radix Glehniae | *Glehnia root*

Nature & Flavor: Sweet, cool

Channels: Lung, Stomach

Primary Actions

1. **Nourishes Lung yin and clears Lung heat**
2. **Nourishes Stomach yin and generates fluids**

Key Indications

- Lung Yin deficiency
Dry cough, Scanty or absent sputum
Hoarse or weak voice, Dry throat, Cough worse in the evening
- Lung Yin deficiency with deficiency heat
Low-grade fever, Night sweating, Five-center heat, Irritability
- Stomach Yin deficiency
Dry mouth and thirst, Poor appetite
Dry retching or nausea without phlegm
Sensation of dryness or burning in the epigastrium
- Post-febrile disease with Yin and fluid injury

Persistent thirst, Dryness, Fatigue with heat signs

Thin, red tongue with little or no coat

- Consumptive patterns
Chronic illness with dryness and weakness, Depletion of fluids and Yin over time

Dosage

- **10–15 g** in decoction (dried root)
- **15–30 g** of the **fresh herb**

Cautions / Contraindications

- Contraindicated in cough due to wind-cold
- Contraindicated in cold-damp or deficient-cold of the Spleen and Stomach
- Incompatible with Lǐ Lú (藜芦)
- Use cautiously with significant dampness or phlegm

Exam Pearl

*Bei Sha Shen is **stronger at clearing heat** than Nan Sha Shen.*

Nán Shā Shēn 南沙参

Radix Adenophorae | *Adenophora root*

Nature & Flavor: Sweet, slightly bitter, cool

Channels: Lung, Stomach

Primary Actions

1. **Nourishes Lung Yin and clears Lung heat**
2. **Nourishes Stomach Yin and generates body fluids**
3. **Transforms phlegm**

Key Indications

- Lung and Stomach yin deficiency with dryness
Dry cough, scanty or sticky sputum
Hoarse or weak voice
Dry throat and mouth
- Post-febrile disease with injury to fluids
Thirst, irritability, residual heat
- Dryness with mild phlegm
Especially when phlegm is difficult to expectorate
- Consumptive patterns affecting Lung Yin

Low-grade fever, night sweats, dry cough

Dosage

- **9–15 g** in decoction (dried root)
- **15–30 g** if using fresh material

Cautions

- Contraindicated in cough due to wind-cold
- Use cautiously in Spleen deficiency with dampness
- Incompatible with Lǐ Lú (藜芦)
- Not appropriate for cold from deficiency of Yang

Exam Pearl

Nan Sha Shen = yin tonic **with mild phlegm-clearing**

Mài Mén Dōng 麦门冬

Radix Ophiopogonis | *Ophiopogon tuber*

Nature & Flavor: Sweet, slightly bitter, slightly cold

Channels: Heart, Lung, Stomach

Primary Actions

1. **Nourishes Lung yin; moistens dryness**
2. **Nourishes Stomach yin; generates fluids**
3. **Clears Heart heat; alleviates irritability**
4. **Moistens Intestines**

Key Indications

- Chronic dry cough; thick, difficult sputum
- Stomach yin deficiency with thirst
- Irritability from deficiency heat

Dosage

- **10-15g** in a decoction

Contraindications

- Damp-phlegm cough due to wind-cold or damp-phlegm accumulation
- Cold type Spleen deficiency diarrhea

Exam Pearl

*Mai Dong uniquely enters the **Heart***

Tiān Mén Dōng 天门冬

Radix Asparagi | *Asparagus tuber*

Nature & Flavor: Sweet, bitter, very cold

Channels: Lung, Kidney

Primary Actions

1. **Clears Lung heat; nourishes Lung yin**
2. **Nourishes Kidney yin**
3. **Moistens Intestines**

Key Indications

- Dry, nonproductive, or scanty-sputum cough, Throat dryness, Hoarse voice, Cough worse in the evening or at night
- Dizziness, Tinnitus, Low back and knee weakness, Night sweats, Five-center heat
- Chronic illness with wasting, Dryness and exhaustion, Deep depletion of fluids and Yin
- Dry, hard stools due to fluid deficiency

Dosage

- **6- 15g** in a decoction

Contraindications

- Cold-deficient diarrhea and cold in the Middle Jiao
- Wind-cold cough

Exam Pearl

*Tiān Dong = **stronger, colder, more drying-counteracting** than Mai Dong*

Shí Hú 石斛

Herba Dendrobii | *Dendrobium*

Nature & Flavor: Sweet, slightly cold

Channels: Stomach, Kidney

Primary Actions

1. **Nourishes Stomach yin; generates fluids**
2. **Clears deficiency heat**
3. **Nourishes Kidney yin**

Key Indications

- Severe thirst from yin deficiency
- Post-febrile qi & yin deficiency

Dosage

- **6-10g** in a decoction
- **15-30g** of fresh herb which strongly clears heat and generates body fluids

Cautions

- Contraindicated in excess febrile disorders, damp-phlegm accumulation on exterior stage diseases
- Not for use during the early stages of warm-febrile disorders

Exam Pearl

Shi Hu = best for **Stomach yin deficiency**

Yù Zhú 玉竹

Rhizoma Polygonati Odorati | *Solomon's seal*

Nature & Flavor: Sweet, neutral

Channels: Lung, Stomach

Primary Actions

1. **Nourishes Lung & Stomach yin**
2. **Moistens dryness**
3. **Releases exterior wind-heat with yin deficiency**

Key Indications

- Non-productive dry cough, scanty, sticky sputum, dry mouth, and thirst
- Hunger with no desire to eat, stomach, and epigastric discomfort.
- Wind-heat invasion causing fever and cough

Dosage

- **10-15g** in a decoction
- Fresh is more effective for yin deficiency heat.

Contraindications

- Dampness or qi stagnation
- Spleen deficiency and phlegm stagnation

Exam Pearl

Yu Zhu = **mildest**; safest with deficiency

Huáng Jīng 黄精

Rhizoma Polygonati | *Polygonatum*

Nature & Flavor: Sweet, neutral

Channels: Lung, Spleen, Kidney

Primary Actions

1. **Tonifies qi & nourishes yin, moistens the Lungs**
2. **Tonifies the Spleen qi & augments the Spleen yin**
3. **Tonifies Kidney and essence**

Key Indications

- Dry cough with little sputum and shortness of breath
- Lassitude, fatigue, loss of appetite, dry mouth, loss of taste, dry stools, dry, red tongue
- Low back pain, lightheadedness, weakness of the lower extremities

Dosage

- **10-20g** in a decoction
- Use 30-60g of fresh herb

Cautions

- Cold-deficient diarrhea

Exam Pearl

Huang Jing bridges **qi + yin deficiency**

Bǎi Hé 百合

Bulbus Lilii | *Lily bulb*

Nature & Flavor: Sweet, slightly bitter, slightly cold

Channels: Lung, Heart

Primary Actions

1. **Moistens Lung; Clears Lung heat, stops cough**
2. **Clears Heart heat; calms Shen**

Key Indications

- Chronic, consumptive, dry cough, shortness of breath, difficult-to-expectorate sputum (white or yellow with streaks of blood)
- Intractable low-grade fever, insomnia, restlessness, irritability after a febrile disease

Dosage

- 10-30g in a decoction

Cautions

- Contraindicated with middle jiao deficiency, diarrhea, or loose stools
 - Do not use in cases of wind-cold invasion or phlegm
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Gǒu Qǐ Zǐ 枸杞子

Fructus Lycii | *Goji berry*

Nature & Flavor: Sweet, neutral

Channels: Liver, Kidney, Lung

Primary Actions

1. **Tonifies Liver & Kidney yin**
2. **Brightens the eyes**
3. **Enriches the Yin & Moistens the Lungs**

Key Indications

- Liver and Kidney deficiency patterns where the essence and blood are unable to nourish the eyes
- Dizziness, blurred vision, diminished visual acuity
- Soreness and weakness of the lower back and knees
- Chronic or consumptive Lung disorders

Dosage

- **5-10g** in a decoction

Contraindications

- Exterior or excess conditions

- Use with caution with patients who have diarrhea due to Spleen deficiency.

Herbal Comparisons

- **Bei vs. Nan Sha Shen:** Heat-clearing vs. phlegm-clearing
- **Mai Dong vs. Tian Dong:** Heart entry vs. stronger Lung/KD yin
- **Shi Hu vs. Yu Zhu:** Deficiency heat vs. gentle moistening

Yin-Tonifying

General identity

All five herbs primarily address **Liver–Kidney Yin deficiency**.
They differ in *what they emphasize*:

Core Emphasis	Herbs
Nourish Yin + stop bleeding	Hán Lián Cǎo
Nourish Yin + clear deficiency heat + brighten eyes	Nǚ Zhēn Zǐ
Nourish Yin + anchor Yang + strengthen bones	Guī Bǎn / Guī Bǎn Jiāo
Nourish Yin + anchor Yang + soften masses	Biē Jiǎ
Nourish Yin + nourish Blood + moisten intestines	Hēi Zhī Má

Quick reference table

Herb	Nature / Flavor	Channels	Primary Exam Actions
Hán Lián Cǎo 旱莲草 (<i>Herba Ecliptae</i>)	Sweet, sour, cool	Liver, Kidney	Tonifies Liver–Kidney Yin; cools Blood; stops bleeding
Nǚ Zhēn Zǐ 女贞子 (<i>Fructus Ligustri Lucidi</i>)	Bitter, sweet, cool	Liver, Kidney	Tonifies Liver–Kidney Yin; clears deficiency heat; brightens eyes

Herb	Nature / Flavor	Channels	Primary Exam Actions
Guī Bǎn 龟板 (<i>Plastrum Testudinis</i>)	Salty, sweet, cold	Heart, Liver, Kidney	Nourishes Yin; anchors Yang; strengthens bones
Guī Bǎn Jiāo 龟板胶 (<i>Gelatin</i>)	Salty, sweet, cold	Heart, Liver, Kidney	Stronger Yin tonic; stops bleeding; nourishes Blood
Biē Jiǎ 鳖甲 (<i>Carapax Trionycis</i>)	Salty, slightly cold	Liver	Nourishes Yin; anchors Yang; softens hardness; dissipates nodules
Hēi Zhī Má 黑芝麻 (<i>Semen Sesami Nigrum</i>)	Sweet, neutral	Liver, Kidney, LI	Nourishes Liver–Kidney Yin; nourishes Blood; moistens intestines

Hán lián cǎo 旱莲草

Herba Ecliptae | False daisy herb

Nature/Flavor: Sweet, sour, cool

Channels: Liver, Kidney

Actions:

1. **Tonifies Liver and Kidney Yin**
2. **Cools Blood and stops bleeding**

Key Indications:

- Liver–Kidney Yin deficiency: dizziness, tinnitus, premature gray hair
- Bleeding due to Yin deficiency heat: hematuria, uterine bleeding, hematemesis

Exam Pearl:

“Yin tonic that also **stops bleeding**.”

Dosage:

- 10–15 g (dried)
- 20–30 g (fresh; stronger cooling and hemostatic)

Cautions:

- Use cautiously in Spleen/Kidney Yang deficiency, cold diarrhea
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Nǚ zhēn zǐ 女贞子

Fructus Ligustri Lucidi | Glossy privet fruit

Nature/Flavor: Bitter, sweet, cool

Channels: Liver, Kidney

Actions:

1. **Tonifies Liver and Kidney Yin**
2. **Clears deficiency heat**
3. **Brightens the eyes**

Key Indications:

- Yin deficiency: dizziness, tinnitus, blurred vision, low back weakness
- Yin deficiency heat: hot flashes, steaming bones

Exam Pearl:

“The Yin tonic that **clears heat and brightens eyes.**”

Dosage:

- 10–15 g

Cautions:

- Contraindicated in Yang deficiency or Spleen/Stomach cold diarrhea
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Guī bǎn 龟板

Plastrum Testudinis | Tortoise (turtle shell)

Nature/Flavor: Salty, sweet, cold

Channels: Heart, Liver, Kidney

Actions:

1. **Nourishes Yin and anchors Yang**
2. **Tonifies Kidney and strengthens bones**
3. **Nourishes Blood and calms Heart Shen**
4. **Stops uterine bleeding**

Key Indications:

- Yin deficiency with Yang rising: dizziness, tinnitus, headaches
- Weak bones, delayed fontanel closure
- Uterine bleeding from deficiency heat

Exam Pearl:

“Heavy Yin tonic that **anchors Yang and strengthens bones.**”

Dosage:

- 10–30 g
(crushed and pre-decocted)

Cautions:

- Contraindicated in pregnancy
- Contraindicated in diarrhea, cold-damp, deficiency cold

Guī bǎn jiāo 龟板胶

Identity: Gelatin extract of Guī Bǎn

Stronger for:

- **Stopping bleeding**
- **Nourishing Blood and Yin**

Dosage:

- 3–10 g, dissolved into strained decoction

Exam Pearl:

“Guī Bǎn Jiāo = **heavier Yin + hemostasis.**”

Biē jiǎ 鳖甲

Carapax Trionycis | Soft-shelled turtle carapace

Nature/Flavor: Salty, slightly cold

Channels: Liver

Actions:

1. **Nourishes Yin and anchors Yang**
2. **Clears deficiency heat**
3. **Softens hardness and dissipates nodules**

Key Indications:

- Yin deficiency with deficiency heat: tidal fevers, night sweats
- Liver wind from Yin deficiency: tremors, spasms
- Masses, nodules, amenorrhea from accumulations

Exam Pearl:

“The Yin tonic that **breaks masses**.”

Dosage:

- 10–30 g
(crushed, pre-decocted)
- Vinegar-processed → better for masses

Cautions:

- Contraindicated in pregnancy
- Contraindicated in Spleen deficiency diarrhea
- Avoid if exterior pathogen not resolved

Hēi zhī má 黑芝麻

Semen Sesami Nigrum | Black sesame seed

Nature/Flavor: Sweet, neutral

Channels: Liver, Kidney, Large Intestine

Actions:

1. **Nourishes Liver and Kidney Yin**
2. **Nourishes Blood**
3. **Moistens and lubricates the intestines**

Key Indications:

- Yin/Blood deficiency: dizziness, blurred vision, premature graying
- Constipation from dryness or Blood deficiency

Exam Pearl:

“The Yin tonic that **treats constipation.**”

Dosage:

- 9–15 g
(often roasted and ground)

Cautions:

- Use cautiously in loose stools or dampness

HIGH-YIELD COMPARISONS

Pair	Distinction
Hán Lián Cǎo vs. Nǚ Zhēn Zǐ	Bleeding vs. heat/eyes
Guī Bǎn vs. Biē Jiǎ	Bone strengthening vs. mass-dissolving
Guī Bǎn Jiāo vs. Guī Bǎn	Blood-stopping vs. structure-building
Hēi Zhī Má vs. Nǚ Zhēn Zǐ	Constipation vs. heat/vision

Clinical META-RULE

Ask:

“Is this Yin deficiency showing up as bleeding, heat, masses, weak bones, or constipation?”

That answer chooses the herb.

